

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

CEO may lead CPS without license

Effort aims to pave way for Johnson pick

By Nell Salzman and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Board members say Mayor Brandon Johnson's hand-picked school board president, Sean Harden, is leading an effort to vote down a resolution requiring the next interim leader of Chicago Public Schools to have a superintendent license, in order to install the mayor's chief of staff, Cristina Pacione-Zayas, to serve in the temporary role.

If approved, the appointment would be a major shift in Johnson's administration and elicit strong reaction from critics of the mayor and his strongest ally, the Chicago Teachers Union.

The search for a new short-term superintendent to fill in for Pedro Martinez, the outgoing CPS chief executive officer, has been the topic of discussion at board meetings and in community forums for months since the CEO was fired without cause in late December amid extreme financial uncertainty. He will stay in his position until mid-June.

Although the board is technically in charge of hiring and firing the district's leader, Johnson appointed the majority of the board and the mayor traditionally influences who is placed in the high-profile role. Board members will likely vote to approve her appointment at May's monthly board meeting.

But first, board members told the Tribune on Wednesday that Harden is trying to corral a majority vote of 11 members to undo a resolution that passed unanimously at a March board meeting, which requires that both the next CEO and the interim CEO must have a "valid

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"I try not to be in spaces where I can't escape readily in the building, or that don't have a lot of visibility. Even if I'm having a bad day, I kind of try to project friendliness because I don't want to give anyone any kind of reason if (a patron is) on edge already to kind of find an excuse to lash out."

— Adrienne Seely, who works at Harold Washington and is vice president of the union that represents Chicago Public Library workers



Several security workers usher a man out of the Harold Washington Library in downtown Chicago on Friday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Anxiety at the library

Harold Washington workers fear for safety with security incidents on rise

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

On a good day, Christopher Crotwell said he will usually leave his job of eight years at Harold Washington Library feeling sad. On a bad day, he will leave feeling angry.

Crotwell works in the computer commons on the third floor, where he said that violent and uncomfortable incidents are a regular occurrence at work.

A few weeks ago, Crotwell woke up a man sleeping at a computer. But what started with a tap on the table to get the man's atten-

tion ended with the patron being escorted out by security, threatening him from the moment he woke up all the way until he was out of Crotwell's sight.

"I generally don't feel unsafe in the city. I'm a pretty confident and happy-go-lucky person. I don't tend to view people that I'm sharing a space with with much suspicion," Crotwell said. But after that, Crotwell bought Mace to keep with him.

"I don't like the way that feels. I don't want to have that in my backpack. I don't want to feel like it's necessary," he said.

Understaffing, inconsistency

in how to enforce rules and insufficient de-escalation training are just some of the issues staff at Harold Washington contend they are facing, some of which staff say are part of broader issues in the Chicago Public Library system. As a result, some staff say they are taking on a heavier-than-usual mental load as they struggle to attend to the needs of their patrons while fulfilling their duties and making the library a welcoming space.

While employees the Tribune spoke with acknowledged that safety has always been a concern at Harold Washington and at the

Chicago Public Library more broadly, employees allege that the issue has only gotten worse in recent months. It's unclear whether more homeless people are appearing at library facilities, even as some staff members say their presence is a factor.

Despite the violence, Crotwell said he feels for the man who threatened him. That man, and many others who come through the building, are some of Chicago's most vulnerable. They need access to the resources the library provides, but providing the best

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CHICAGO CITY COUNCIL

Plan to spur affordable housing gets green light

Policy uses public fund to finance construction

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's plan to spur affordable housing construction with a new loan fund finally passed in the City Council Wednesday after weeks of wrangling.

The passage of Johnson's ambitious "Green Social Housing" plan marks one of the mayor's first major legislative wins of the year, one he will certainly point out to his progressive base as evidence he is delivering on his agenda.

And the novel policy that will use a revolving pool of city cash to help finance housing construction could serve as an example



Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson smiles while talking to reporters after a City Council meeting Wednesday. Council members approved Johnson's affordable housing plan. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

for other locales seeking to build affordable homes amid waning federal support, even as some aldermen worried Wednesday that it doesn't go nearly far enough.

"The people of Chicago have called for more affordable units, and that's exactly what we're doing," Johnson said after the vote. "We are going to build the safest, most affordable big city in America."

The measure had been hampered by a series of thorny questions, but sped through first a committee vote and a final vote

Wednesday. Aldermen approved in a 30-18 vote the ordinance to create a nonprofit structure charged with loaning out the fund's \$135 million.

Only one alderman testified about the policy at the council meeting before the Wednesday afternoon vote, a sign of the exhaustive conversations that had already taken place.

On Wednesday morning, a council joint committee held its third meeting on the ordinance. Ald. Jessie Fuentes said then it's

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Pakistan calls Indian airstrikes act of war

By Munir Ahmed, Sheikh Saaliq, Riazat Butt, Rajesh Roy and Aijaz Hussain
Associated Press

ISLAMABAD — Pakistan said Wednesday it will avenge those killed by India's missile strikes that New Delhi called retaliation for last month's massacre of Indian tourists in India-controlled Kashmir. Pakistan called the strikes an act of war and claimed it downed several Indian fighter jets.

The missiles killed 31 people, including women and children, in Pakistan-administered Kashmir and the country's Punjab province, Pakistan's military said. The strikes targeted at least nine sites "where terrorist attacks against India have been planned," India's Defense Ministry said. Two mosques were hit.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said his country would avenge the dead but gave no details, fanning fears of all-out conflict between the nuclear-armed rivals. Already, it's their worst confrontation since 2019,

when they came close to war.

A heavy exchange of fire continued following the missile strikes, and officials in each country confirmed people killed. Sharif commended the armed forces for shooting down five Indian jets, which he said were hit after they fired their missiles but while still in Indian airspace.

There was no comment from India, but three planes fell onto villages in India-controlled territory, according to police and residents.

Tensions have soared between the neighbors since the April attack in which gunmen killed 26 people, mostly Indian tourists. Some survivors told Indian media that gunmen in some cases singled out Hindu men and shot them at close range.

India accuses Pakistan of being behind the attack, which was claimed by a militant group calling itself Kashmir Resistance. India has said the group is linked to Lashkar-e-Taiba, a disbanded Pakistani militant group that

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Ex-CPS principal found dead

A former Brennemann Elementary principal was found dead Tuesday after she failed to show up for sentencing in an overtime kickback scheme. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Amid black smoke, no pope yet

Black smoke poured out of the Sistine Chapel chimney Wednesday, signaling that no pope had been elected on the first day of the centuries-old ritual. **Nation & World**

Could the Bulls land Giannis?

Bulls fans may be dreaming of the "Greek Freak" in a red and black jersey, but trading for Giannis Antetokounmpo would likely come with big sacrifices. **Chicago Sports**

